

SIMPLE LESSONS:

In a small stone cabin at the edge of a forest, there lived a boy and his old grandmother. The grandmother had lived a long time and had been to many exciting and faraway places. The boy was very curious about her adventures and wanted to learn about the clever elves and giants and dragons that she had met. The grandmother promised to teach her grandson one lesson each day, until he was ready to go out into the world on his own. The boy expected these lessons to be daring and dangerous, but most days the grandmother taught him very ordinary chores. She taught him how to bake bread and make soup. She taught him how to weave a reed basket and sew a leather pouch. The boy was disappointed that the lessons were not more exciting, but he was very willing to learn just the same.

He knew that his grandmother was very wise, and that she understood what skills he would need to get along in the world. So, during each lesson, no matter how simple, he listened carefully, paid close attention, and worked his hardest. Sure enough, when the boy set out on his own, right away he met up with an angry troll who demanded a loaf of home-baked bread. Luckily, the boy had learned to bake bread from his wise grandmother. Later, the boy met a wicked witch who wanted to turn him into a turtle so she could make delicious soup. The boy thought fast, and since he had also learned to make delicious soup, he was able to cook for the witch and then run away. Another time, a huge dragon asked the boy to carry her eggs up the mountains to her nest. The boy was able to quickly weave a reed basket to safely hold all the eggs. The dragon rewarded him with many gold coins. All through his life, the boy had many exciting adventures, and time after time he realized that the simple lessons he had learned as a child were the most important things that helped as he grew up to be a man.